“colored” to convey a potential connection with U.S. racial discourse; in this way and others throughout the poem, Lorde opens herself up as an additional, if not central, subject of the piece.[55]

Lorde begins her poem in the time-space of a dream and in the geopolitical reality of divided Berlin. The poem opens in a dream state, with the word “Perhaps” announcing its beginning and serving as a refrain throughout the remaining stanzas, as a “ strange woman” sneaks into her bedroom at night, “wasps nest behind her ears.”[56] In this poem, Lorde introduces this woman, and Berlin, through a matrix of diasporic images. The symbols in the first stanza—“kittiwake” birds, “lizard,” and “gray whales”—conjure the tropics by the sea and thus connect readers to Lorde’s other non-American homespaces, in Grenada and Saint Croix. The poem stands in as an encoded diasporic map, including divided Berlin. The possessive “my bedroom” stages an interaction that starts with an intrusion and cedes to acts of shared movement and translation.[57]

As the poem progresses, Lorde imagines ways to approach and transgress the Berlin Wall. The internal border of the Wall functions here along several lines as a divider: it marks the spatial divide between the poem’s two stanzas, the introduction of the narrative “I,” and the divider between one day ending and the next beginning.[58] By the second stanza, the speaker traverses the city’s internal border at the Wall, and the narrative perspective changes to the first person: “I cross her borders at midnight / the guards confused by a dream.” Like Angela Davis before her, Lorde conjures a scene of border crossing without mentioning “The Berlin Wall” in this poem. In addition to resisting the Wall’s monumental nomenclature, Lorde finds several ways to locate and then transgress the poem’s alluded boundary. She accounts for the Wall not through direct naming or its concrete architecture but instead through the language of “borders,” “guards,” and temporal and geopolitical trickery.

Midnight as a poetic time of liminality is crucial to this poem. The nighttime offers a charged temporal space, as it suggests uncertainty, ambivalence, and possibility, while signaling intimacy between women.[59] In Berlin’s geopolitical time, midnight is significant, as it is a clear reference to the actual East German policy in which all sanctioned daily visitors from West Berlin would report and return back across the border-crossing checkpoints. The poem’s travel after midnight suggests that border control ultimately fails to keep the city’s division intact. In crossing the borders after